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CUET UG

History

Vijayanagara Empire: Politics, Economy and Architecture

Themes in Indian History Part II · Chapter 7 · An Imperial Capital: Vijayanagara (c. 1336–1565 CE)

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Official Syllabus Breakdown & Exam Scope

The Vijayanagara Empire represents one of the most heavily tested medieval themes in the NTA CUET UG History examination. Derived from **Themes in Indian History Part II** (Chapter 7: "An Imperial Capital: Vijayanagara"), this unit assesses structural statecraft, geopolitical rivalries, military feudalism (**Amaranayaka** system), hydraulic civil engineering, and imperial monumental architecture.

Sub-topic	Official syllabus pointer & key NCERT anchors	Skills the questions test
1. Discovery & Historiography	Colonel Colin Mackenzie (1800), East India Company cartography, local oral traditions of Virupaksha and Pampa Devi, photographic documentation (Alexander Greenlaw), epigraphic surveys (Fleet, Rice).	Historiographical timelines, surveyor appointments, archaeological methodology.
2. Dynastic Evolution & Zeniths	Four dynasties (Sangama, Saluva, Tuluva, Aravidu); Krishnadeva Raya (1509–1529); Raichur Doab conquest; founding of Nagalapuram; Telugu treatise **Amuktamalyada**; Battle of Talikota (1565).	Chronological matching, primary literary attribution, geopolitical causes of imperial collapse.
3. Military Feudalism & Economy	**Amaranayaka** system; comparison with Delhi Sultanate **Iqta**; military contingents; **kudirai chettis**; Portuguese horse trade monopoly; trade in spices, textiles, and precious gems.	Institutional comparison, fiscal mechanics, foreign trade networks.
4. Urban Topography & Engineering	Tungabhadra natural amphitheatre; Kamalapuram tank; Hiriya canal; Abdur Razzaq's 7 concentric fortification walls; inclusion of agricultural tracts within fortifications.	Spatial analysis, hydraulic terminology, foreign traveler testimony evaluation.
5. Sacred & Royal Architecture	Royal Centre (Mahanavami Dibba, Lotus Mahal, Hazara Rama, Elephant Stables); Sacred Centre (Virupaksha Temple, Vitthala Temple, **rayagopurams**, **kalyana mandapas**).	Architectural typology, ritual statecraft symbolism, stylistic synthesis (Indo-Islamic elements).

HIGH-YIELD NTA CUET TRAP: THE FOUR DYNASTIES SEQUENCE

NTA frequently tests the strict chronological succession of the four ruling houses of Vijayanagara:

Sangama (1336–1485) → **Saluva** (1485–1505) → **Tuluva** (1505–1570) → **Aravidu** (1570–c. 1646)

Note that Krishnadeva Raya belonged to the **Tuluva** dynasty, whereas founders Harihara I and Bukka I belonged to the **Sangama** dynasty. The Aravidu dynasty ruled after the catastrophic defeat at Talikota (1565), operating from Penukonda and later Chandragiri.

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Sub-Topic 1: Discovery of Hampi and Historiographical Recovery

1.1 Colonel Colin Mackenzie and Early Cartography

The ruins at Hampi were brought to academic and administrative notice in **1800** by **Colonel Colin Mackenzie**, an engineer, cartographer, and antiquarian employed by the English East India Company. Mackenzie prepared the first comprehensive survey map of the site. His initial reconstructions relied on:

- Physical site surveys and topological mapping of the boulder-strewn Tungabhadra basin.
- Memories and oral testimonies elicited from the priests (**archakas**) of the functioning Virupaksha temple and the shrine of the mother goddess **Pampadevi**.
- Inscriptions preserved on stone tablets, copper plates, and temple boundary steles in Kannada, Telugu, Sanskrit, and Tamil.

Mackenzie was subsequently appointed as the **first Surveyor General of India** in **1815**, a post he held until his death in 1821. His vast collection of regional manuscripts and epigraphic rubbings formed the foundational corpus for South Indian epigraphy.

1.2 Photographic and Epigraphic Documentation

Following Mackenzie's survey, archaeological recovery advanced through successive technological phases:

- **1856**: Photographer **Alexander Greenlaw** produced the earliest extensive photographic documentation of the architectural remains at Hampi, providing invaluable benchmark records prior to twentieth-century weathering.
- **1876**: **J.F. Fleet** began systematically copying and cataloging epigraphic inscriptions found on temple walls and victory pillars.
- **1902**: Under the directorship of **John Marshall**, the Archaeological Survey of India (ASI) initiated formal structural conservation and clearing operations.
- **1976**: The site of Hampi was officially recognized as an archaeological site of national importance, leading to international collaborative projects (e.g., the Vijayanagara Research Project led by George Michell and Fritz) and its designation as a UNESCO World Heritage Site in **1986**.

1.3 Foreign Travel Accounts as Historiographical Anchors

A key dimension of CUET questions involves matching contemporary foreign travelers with their countries of origin, royal reigns visited, and specific urban observations:

Traveler	Origin	Century / Reign	Key Descriptive Contributions
Nicolo de Conti	Italian merchant	1420 (Devaraya I)	Early description of the city's perimeter, massive population, and court festivals.
Abdur Razzaq Samarqandi	Persian ambassador	1440s (Devaraya II)	Documented the **seven concentric lines of fortifications** enclosing agricultural fields; described the palace of the king and mint.
Duarte Barbosa	Portuguese official	c. 1518 (Krishnadeva Raya)	Detailed accounts of trade in precious jewels, pearls, diamonds, and horses; observed royal lifestyle and religious toleration.
Domingo Paes	Portuguese horse trader/ visitor	c. 1520–1522 (Krishnadeva Raya)	Vivid eyewitness account of the **Mahanavami Dibba** ceremonies, Krishnadeva Raya's appearance, urban markets, and irrigation tanks.
Fernao Nuniz	Portuguese horse dealer	c. 1535–1537 (Achyuta Deva Raya)	Chronicle of dynastic wars, detailed functioning and revenue extraction of the **Amaranayaka** system.

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Sub-Topic 2: Dynastic Evolution, Political Expansion, and the Zenith of Krishnadeva Raya

2.1 Foundation and Sacred Geography

The Vijayanagara Empire was founded in **1336 CE** by two brothers, **Harihara I** and **Bukka I**, feudatories of the Kakatiyas of Warangal and later officers in the Sultanate administration of Kampili. The capital was established on the southern bank of the **Tungabhadra** river, nestled among rugged granite hills.

The choice of site was deliberate, synthesizing strategic natural defensibility with deep sacred legitimacy:

- The region was identified with the mythical **Kishkindha** of the **Ramayana**, the monkey kingdom of Vali, Sugriva, and Hanuman.
- The local river goddess, **Pampadevi**, had performed penance on these granite crags to win the hand of **Virupaksha**, a manifestation of Shiva and the guardian deity of the realm.

- Vijayanagara kings claimed to rule on behalf of Lord Virupaksha. Royal orders were signed with the Kannada script invocation **"Sri Virupaksha"**. Kings also assumed the title **"Hindu Suratrana"** (a Sanskritisation of the Arabic **Sultan**, meaning "Sultan among Hindu Kings"), signaling both ideological accommodation and political parity with northern contemporaries.

CONCEPTUAL INSIGHT: SACRED SOVEREIGNTY AND ROYAL TITULATURE

Vijayanagara monarchs did not claim divine status in isolation; rather, they acted as divine regents. By signing all official edicts as **Sri Virupaksha** and adopting the hybridized title **Hindu Suratrana**, the Rayas drew legitimacy simultaneously from indigenous temple networks and cosmopolitan Sultanate statecraft.

2.2 The Four Dynasties of Vijayanagara

1. **Sangama Dynasty (1336–1485 CE)**: Founded by Harihara and Bukka; expanded control over Karnataka, Andhra, and Tamil regions; fought prolonged wars against the Bahmani Sultanate over the fertile **Raichur Doab** (the interfluvial tract between the Krishna and Tungabhadra rivers) and the Krishna-Godavari delta.
2. **Saluva Dynasty (1485–1505 CE)**: Military commanders (**saluvas**) staged a palace coup to usurp power when Sangama rule disintegrated into factional infighting.
3. **Tuluva Dynasty (1505–1570 CE)**: Established by Vira Narasimha; reached the apex of imperial prestige and territorial expansion under his half-brother **Krishnadeva Raya** (1509–1529 CE).
4. **Aravidu Dynasty (1570–c. 1646 CE)**: Founded by Tirumala (brother of Rama Raya) following the disaster of Talikota; ruled from the hill fortresses of Penukonda and Chandragiri until gradual territorial fragmentation by Bijapur and Golconda.

2.3 The Zenith under Krishnadeva Raya (1509–1529 CE)

Krishnadeva Raya's reign is universally celebrated as the golden age of Vijayanagara statecraft:

- **Military Campaigns**: In 1512, he subjugated the fertile **Raichur Doab**. In 1514, he captured the fortress of Udayagiri from the Gajapati ruler of Orissa (Prataparudra), followed by Kondavidu (1515). He decisively checked the armies of Sultan Ismail Adil Shah of Bijapur.
- **Urban Foundation**: Near Vijayanagara, he established a suburban township named **Nagalapuram**, in memory of his mother Nagala Devi.
- **Literary Contributions**: A great patron of letters, he composed **Amuktamalyada** ("Giver of the Worn Garland") in Telugu, an epic poem detailing the life of the Vaishnava Alvar saint Andal, featuring extensive discourses on statecraft, trade, and military logistics. In Sanskrit, he authored the drama **Jambavati Kalyanam**.
- **Temple Patronage**: He added the magnificent pillared hall (**mandapa**) in front of the sanctum of the Virupaksha temple and constructed the soaring eastern **rayagopuram** (temple gateway).

2.4 The Battle of Talikota (Rakshasi-Tangadi) and Imperial Decline

Following Krishnadeva Raya's death in 1529, dynastic succession was contested among royal pretenders and powerful military commanders (**nayakas**):

- Krishnadeva Raya was succeeded by Achyuta Deva Raya (1529–1542) and subsequently Sadashiva Raya (1542–1570). Real political power, however, fell into the hands of the chief minister, **Aliya Rama Raya** (son-in-law of Krishnadeva Raya).
- **Geopolitical Miscalculation**: Rama Raya attempted to play off one Deccan Sultanate against another (Bijapur, Golconda, Ahmadnagar, and Bidar) through Machiavellian diplomacy. Eventually, the Sultanates forged a grand confederacy against Vijayanagara.
- **The Battle**: On **23 January 1565**, the combined armies of Bijapur, Ahmadnagar, Golconda, and Bidar met the Vijayanagara army at **Rakshasi-Tangadi** (commonly known as the **Battle of Talikota**).
- **Outcome**: Rama Raya was captured and executed. The imperial army was routed. The victorious Sultanate armies entered the undefended capital, systematically looting and destroying its monumental structures over several months.
- The seat of imperial power shifted eastward to **Penukonda** and later **Chandragiri**, under the **Aravidu** dynasty.

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Sub-Topic 3: Visualizing Imperial Spatial Hierarchy and Urban Topography

To comprehend how the imperial capital operated, historians analyze its zoned spatial layout. The capital was structured into distinctive functional sectors: the Sacred Centre along the river, the Urban Core, and the Royal Centre.

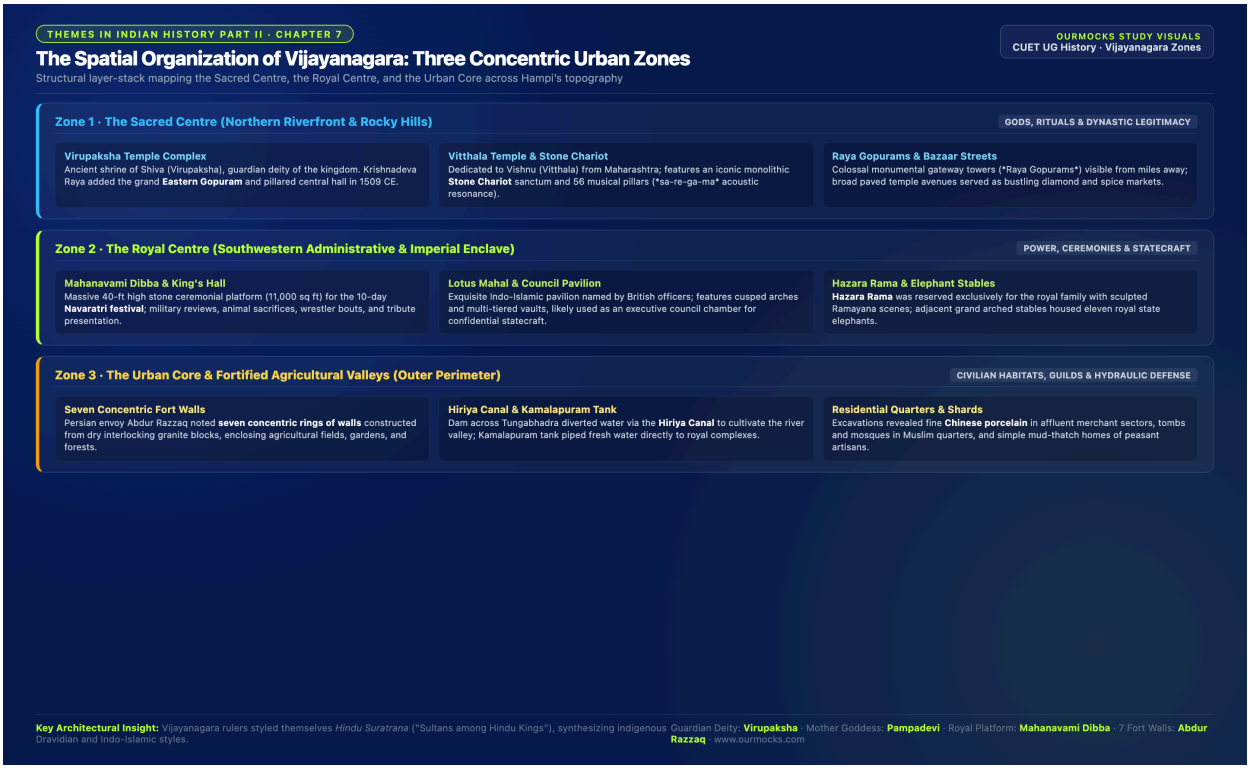


Figure 1: Spatial Layout and Tripartite Zonation of the Imperial Capital Vijayanagara

3.1 Zonation Analysis

1. **The Sacred Centre**: Located on the northern rocky perimeter hugging the southern bank of the Tungabhadra. It encompassed ancient pilgrimage sites (Virupaksha, Pampadevi) and massive imperial temple complexes (Vitthala, Krishna, Achyutaraya). Temples here were economic hubs featuring grand pillared **bazaars** extending from their gopurams.
2. **The Royal Centre**: Situated in the south-western part of the settlement. It contained over 60 temples and more than 30 palace structures. Built with high stone enclosures, it was divided into distinct compounds:
   - **Public Ritual Arenas**: Centered around the **Mahanavami Dibba**.
   - **Council and Audience Enclosures**: Including the **Lotus Mahal** and King's Audience Hall.
   - **Elite Private Quarters**: The Zenana enclosures and the **Hazara Rama** temple.
3. **The Urban Core**: Occupying the central and south-eastern plateau, this zone housed civil officials, merchants, soldiers, and artisans. Archaeological surveys revealed Chinese porcelain fragments, iron-smelting kilns, mosques, and tombs of Muslim officers, indicating a diverse, cosmopolitan urban populace.
4. **Agricultural & Hydraulic Buffer**: Vast tracts of irrigated rice paddies, orchards, and gardens intentionally integrated between concentric fortification walls to withstand prolonged military sieges.

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Sub-Topic 4: Hydraulic Infrastructure and Defensive Engineering

The physical environment of Vijayanagara is defined by the natural basin formed by the river **Tungabhadra**, which flows in a north-easterly direction. Granite boulder hills encircle this valley

like a natural amphitheatre. Because rainfall in the semi-arid Rayalaseema plateau was low and seasonal, imperial survival depended on state-of-the-art hydraulic civil engineering.

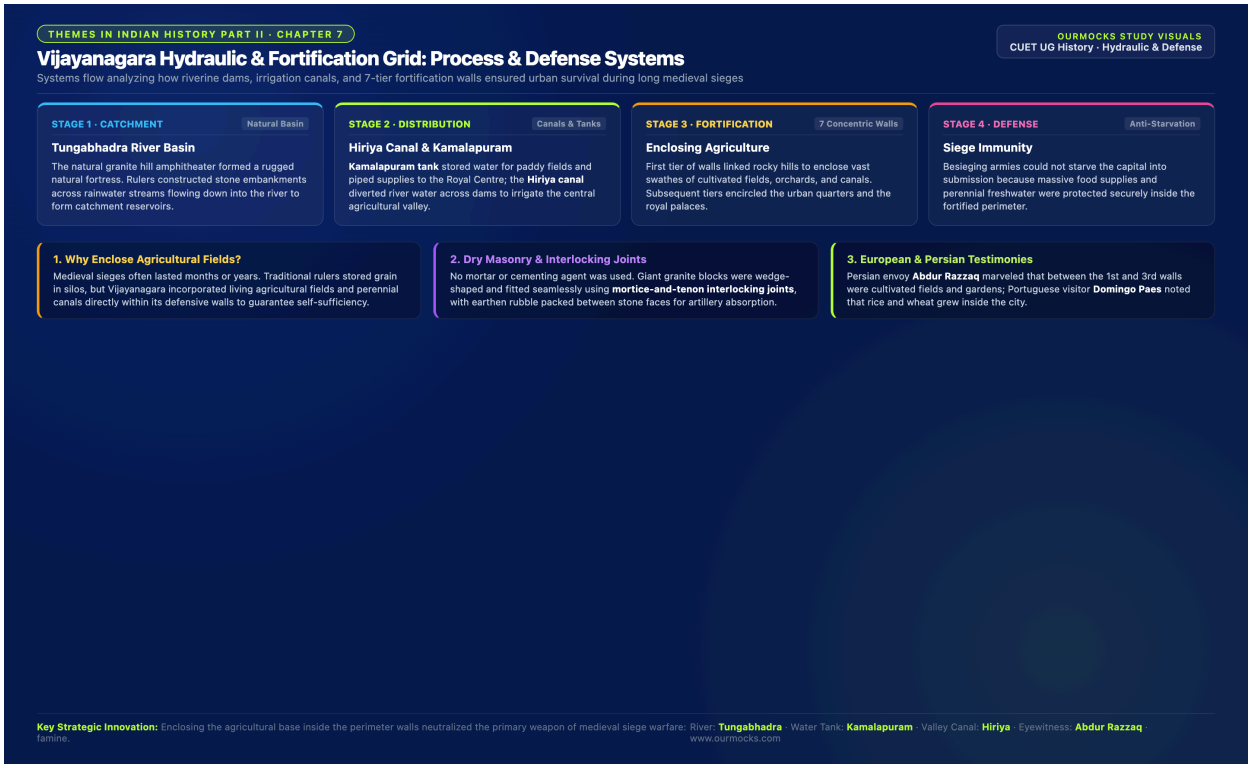


Figure 2: Hydraulic Infrastructure and Seven-Tier Defensive Engineering System

4.1 Key Hydraulic Networks

- **Kamalapuram Tank**: Built in the early fifteenth century, this massive reservoir harvested seasonal hillside runoff. Water from the tank was conveyed via aqueducts into the Royal Centre for domestic and ceremonial consumption, while excess overflow irrigated adjacent paddy fields.
- **Hiriya Canal**: One of the most prominent canals, it drew water from a dam built across the Tungabhadra and channeled it through the fertile valley separating the Sacred Centre from the Urban Core.
- **Masonry Channels and Piped Conduits**: Terracotta and carved granite stone pipes distributed pressurized water to bathhouses, royal pleasure pavilions (such as the Queen's Bath), and temple tanks (**kalyani**).

4.2 The Seven Lines of Fortifications

The Persian ambassador **Abdur Razzaq**, visiting during the reign of Devaraya II in the 1440s, was astonished by the defensive fortifications:

- **Concentric Ring Architecture**: The city was defended by **seven concentric circles of walls**.
- **Enclosing Agricultural Fields**: Crucially, Abdur Razzaq observed that the outermost walls did not merely encircle residential quarters, but enclosed extensive agricultural tracts, cultivated fields, orchards, and forested zones.
- **Strategic Rationale**: In medieval siege warfare, attackers sought to starve defenders into surrender over months or years. By enclosing internal granaries, standing crops, and canal-fed rice paddies, Vijayanagara could withstand prolonged sieges without food shortages.

- **Dry Stone Masonry**: The walls were constructed using wedge-shaped granite blocks without any mortar or cementing paste. Blocks were held securely in place by sophisticated mortise-and-tenon interlocking joints.
- **Fortified Gateways**: Entrances were heavily guarded bastions featuring monumental arched passageways influenced by Indo-Islamic architectural elements, topped with plaster domes.

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Sub-Topic 5: The Amaranayaka Feudal System and Military Economy

5.1 Structure of the Amaranayaka System

The **Amaranayaka system** was a major political and administrative innovation of the Vijayanagara Empire. Many features of this system were derived from the **Iqta** system of the Delhi Sultanate:

- **Amaranayakas**: Military commanders (**nayakas**) were assigned territories (**amaram**) by the Raya to govern and extract revenue. The word **amara** is believed to be derived from the Sanskrit word **samara** (meaning battle or warfare), though some link it to the Persian **amir** (noble).
- **Fiscal & Military Obligations**:
  - The Amaranayakas collected taxes and agricultural dues from peasants, craftspersons, and merchants in their jurisdiction.
  - A stipulated portion of the revenue was retained by the nayaka to maintain his personal household, finance public works (clearing forests and maintaining irrigation tanks), and maintain a fixed contingent of horses, elephants, and infantry.
  - These military contingents provided the Raya with an effective standing fighting force without burdening the central imperial treasury with day-to-day upkeep.
- **Imperial Remittances and Court Ceremonies**:
  - The nayakas sent an annual cash tribute to the imperial treasury.
  - Once a year, during the grand **Mahanavami** festival, they were required to appear personally at the imperial court bearing lavish gifts for the emperor to reaffirm their feudal loyalty.
- **Crown Control and Instability**:
  - The Raya retained the sovereign prerogative to transfer nayakas from one province to another to prevent local power bases from solidifying.
  - However, during the late sixteenth and seventeenth centuries, central royal authority deteriorated, allowing powerful nayakas (such as the Nayakas of Madurai, Thanjavur, and Senji) to establish autonomous regional kingdoms.

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Feature	Vijayanagara Amaranayaka System	Delhi Sultanate Iqta System
Primary Function	Feudal military tenure; provincial defense and revenue extraction.	Administrative and revenue assignment to nobles/military commanders.
Transferability	Monarch exercised power of transfer, though hereditary tenures emerged frequently.	Strict periodic transfers enforced under strong Sultans (e.g., Alauddin Khalji).
Ritual Loyalty	Mandatory personal attendance and gift presentation at **Mahanavami** festival.	Submission of annual audit accounts (**fawazil**) to central diwan.
Regional Impact	Led to independent southern Nayaka kingdoms after imperial collapse.	Fragmented during weak reigns into regional Sultanates (Jaunpur, Bengal, Malwa).

5.2 War Horse Trade and Mercantile Networks

Military dominance on the Deccan plateau depended heavily on cavalry. Because indigenous Indian horse breeds were poorly suited for heavy cavalry warfare, the Rayas relied entirely on imported Arabian and Central Asian war horses:

- **Kudirai Chettis**: Local merchant guilds (**kudirai chettis**, literally "horse merchants") organized the import and auction of horses arriving at western coastal ports (Goa, Bhatkal, Honavar).
- **Portuguese Interventions**: Following their capture of Goa in 1510, the Portuguese, under figures like Afonso de Albuquerque, established a virtual naval monopoly over the Arabian horse trade. Krishnadeva Raya maintained close diplomatic and mercantile relations with the Portuguese to guarantee exclusive supplies of premier horses and advanced gunpowder technology.

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Sub-Topic 6: Royal and Sacred Architecture: Imperial Monumentality

6.1 The Royal Centre and Ritual Monuments

- **The Mahanavami Dibba**: A colossal stone platform rising from a base of approximately 11,000 square feet to a height of 40 feet. It is adorned with intricate bas-relief carvings depicting hunting scenes, horse processions, musicians, and courtly dancers.
  - **Ritual Function**: During the ten-day **Mahanavami** festival (held in the autumn month of Ashvin), the Raya conducted state ceremonies from this platform. Ceremonies included the worship of the state horse, buffalo sacrifices, military parades, and the formal submission of tribute by the **Amaranayakas**.
- **Audience Hall and Lotus Mahal**:

- The **King's Audience Hall** was a high platform with closely spaced wooden pillars supporting an upper storey.
- The **Lotus Mahal**, so named by nineteenth-century British visitors, was an elegant pavilion featuring cusped lobed arches, vaulted ceilings, and Islamic-style stucco work, likely serving as a royal council chamber where the king met confidential advisers.

- **Hazara Rama Temple**: Located within the Royal Centre, this temple was reserved exclusively for the king and the royal family. Its inner courtyard walls are carved with complete narrative scenes from the **Ramayana**.
- **Elephant Stables**: A grand structure situated adjacent to the Zenana enclosure, consisting of eleven vaulted chambers topped with domes influenced by Deccan Indo-Islamic architectural idioms.

6.2 The Sacred Centre and Temple Complex Innovations

Vijayanagara temple architecture represented the climactic synthesis of earlier Chola, Hoysala, and Chalukya traditions, enhanced by monumental scale:

- **Rayagopurams (Royal Gateways)**: Soaring multi-tiered entrance towers that dwarfed the central sanctum (**garbhagriha**), serving as visible beacons of royal power from miles away.
- **Mandapas and Kalyana Mandapas**: Expansive pillared pavilions. The **Kalyana Mandapa** was an ornate open hall designed specifically for celebrating the divine marriage of the deity (**kalyanotsavam**).
- **Virupaksha Temple**: Dating back to the 9th–10th centuries, this ancient shrine was substantially enlarged by Vijayanagara rulers. Krishnadeva Raya constructed the open pillared hall (**ranga mandapa**) in 1509 to mark his accession, embellishing it with finely carved floral and mythical animal reliefs.
- **Vitthala Temple**: Dedicated to **Vitthala**, a form of Vishnu worshipped primarily in Maharashtra. The presence of this shrine highlights the cultural and religious integration achieved by the empire. The complex features:
  - The celebrated **Stone Chariot** (**ratha**), a shrine modeled as a ceremonial processional temple chariot with rotating granite wheels.
  - The main **mandapa**, supported by 56 monolithic **musical pillars** that emit distinct musical tones when tapped.

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Sub-Topic 7: Comprehensive Chapter Synthesizer Mindmap

To unify dynastic, administrative, hydraulic, and architectural dimensions for quick pre-exam revision, the conceptual framework below maps all core historical linkages:



Figure 3: Master Architectural Mindmap of Vijayanagara Statecraft and Material Culture

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High-Yield Chronology & Nomenclature Reference

Year / Period	Historical Event & Imperial Milestone
1336 CE	Foundation of Vijayanagara Empire by Harihara I and Bukka I (Sangama Dynasty).
1420 CE	Italian merchant Nicolo de Conti visits the capital during the reign of Devaraya I.
1443 CE	Persian envoy Abdur Razzaq Samarqandi visits Vijayanagara; documents 7 concentric fortifications.
1485 CE	Saluva Narasimha overthrows the Sangama dynasty; initiates Saluva dynastic rule.
1505 CE	Vira Narasimha establishes the Tuluva dynasty.
1509–1529 CE	Reign of Krishnadeva Raya; conquest of Raichur Doab (1512); composition of **Amuktamalyada**.
1520–1522 CE	Portuguese traveler Domingo Paes visits and documents the city and the Mahanavami festival.
1535–1537 CE	Fernao Nuniz chronicles the empire during the reign of Achyuta Deva Raya.

Year / Period	Historical Event & Imperial Milestone
1565 CE (23 Jan)	Battle of Talikota (Rakshasi-Tangadi); allied Deccan Sultanates defeat and sack Vijayanagara.
1570 CE	Establishment of Aravidu dynasty at Penukonda by Tirumala Raya.
1800 CE	Colonel Colin Mackenzie discovers and maps the ruins of Hampi.
1986 CE	Hampi declared a UNESCO World Heritage Site.

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High-Yield NTA CUET Practice Questions (15 MCQs)

Q1. Who among the following British officers prepared the first comprehensive survey map of the Hampi ruins in 1800?

(A) Alexander Greenlaw
(B) Colonel Colin Mackenzie
(C) John Marshall
(D) J.F. Fleet

Sol. Q1. Colonel Colin Mackenzie, an antiquarian and cartographer of the English East India Company, visited Hampi in 1800 and produced its first survey map. He was appointed the first Surveyor General of India in 1815.

Answer: (B)

Q2. The rulers of Vijayanagara signed all official royal edicts in the Kannada script in the name of which deity?

(A) Lord Vitthala
(B) Lord Venkateshwara
(C) Lord Virupaksha
(D) Goddess Pampadevi

Sol. Q2. Vijayanagara monarchs claimed to govern on behalf of Lord Virupaksha, the guardian deity of the realm. All official royal edicts were signed as **Sri Virupaksha** in the Kannada script.

Answer: (C)

Q3. Which Persian ambassador visited the Vijayanagara Empire in the 1440s and documented the existence of seven concentric lines of fortifications enclosing agricultural fields?

(A) Duarte Barbosa
(B) Nicolo de Conti
(C) Fernao Nuniz
(D) Abdur Razzaq Samarqandi

Sol. Q3. Abdur Razzaq Samarqandi, sent by the ruler of Persia, visited Vijayanagara in the 1440s during the reign of Devaraya II. He specifically recorded seven rings of fortification enclosing agricultural fields and orchards.

Answer: (D)

Q4. Match the foreign traveler with their respective country of origin: (a) Nicolo de Conti — 1. Persia (b) Abdur Razzaq — 2. Italy (c) Domingo Paes — 3. Portugal (d) Fernao Nuniz — 4. Portugal

(A) (a)-2, (b)-1, (c)-3, (d)-4
(B) (a)-1, (b)-2, (c)-3, (d)-4
(C) (a)-2, (b)-3, (c)-1, (d)-4
(D) (a)-3, (b)-1, (c)-2, (d)-4

Sol. Q4. Nicolo de Conti was an Italian merchant (1420); Abdur Razzaq was a Persian ambassador (1440s); Domingo Paes (1520s) and Fernao Nuniz (1530s) were Portuguese visitors.

Answer: (A)

Q5. The **Amaranayaka** system of Vijayanagara was conceptually and structurally derived from which administrative framework?

(A) The Mansabdari system of the Mughals
(B) The Iqta system of the Delhi Sultanate
(C) The Nayankara system of the Kakatiyas only
(D) The Mirasdari system of the Deccan

Sol. Q5. NCERT explicitly notes that many features of the Amaranayaka system were derived from the **Iqta** system of the Delhi Sultanate, where military commanders were assigned revenue-bearing territories.

Answer: (B)

Q6. Which of the following dynasties ruled Vijayanagara in the correct chronological order?

(A) Sangama -> Tuluva -> Saluva -> Aravidu
(B) Saluva -> Sangama -> Tuluva -> Aravidu
(C) Sangama -> Saluva -> Tuluva -> Aravidu
(D) Tuluva -> Sangama -> Saluva -> Aravidu

Sol. Q6. The correct chronological succession is: Sangama (1336–1485) -> Saluva (1485–1505) -> Tuluva (1505–1570) -> Aravidu (1570–c. 1646).

Answer: (C)

Q7. Krishnadeva Raya authored the celebrated political and poetic treatise **Amuktamalyada** in which language?

(A) Sanskrit
(B) Kannada
(C) Tamil
(D) Telugu

Sol. Q7. Krishnadeva Raya composed **Amuktamalyada** in Telugu. It details the life of Alvar saint Andal and contains vital principles of medieval statecraft.

Answer: (D)

Q8. Which suburban township was founded by Krishnadeva Raya near Vijayanagara in honor of his mother?

(A) Hospet
(B) Nagalapuram
(C) Kamalapuram
(D) Penukonda

Sol. Q8. Krishnadeva Raya founded the suburban township of **Nagalapuram** near the capital in memory of his mother, Nagala Devi.

Answer: (B)

Q9. The colossal multi-tiered entrance towers constructed by Vijayanagara rulers that signaled imperial temple patronage from great distances were termed:

(A) Garbhagrihas
(B) Kalyana Mandapas
(C) Rayagopurams
(D) Shikharas

Sol. Q9. Monumental temple gateways built by the Rayas were called **rayagopurams** (royal gopurams). They often towered over the inner shrines.

Answer: (C)

Q10. The decisive Battle of Talikota (Rakshasi-Tangadi), which led to the devastation of Vijayanagara, was fought on:

(A) 1526 CE
(B) 1556 CE
(C) 1565 CE
(D) 1576 CE

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Sol. Q10. The Battle of Talikota took place on 23 January 1565, when the combined armies of Bijapur, Ahmadnagar, Golconda, and Bidar defeated the Vijayanagara army commanded by Rama Raya.

Answer: (C)

Q11. The sacred Vitthala temple at Vijayanagara is dedicated to a principal form of Vishnu who was traditionally worshipped in which region?

(A) Tamil Nadu
(B) Maharashtra
(C) Orissa
(D) Gujarat

Sol. Q11. Vitthala is a manifestation of Vishnu traditionally worshipped in Maharashtra (Pandharpur). The introduction of his worship at Vijayanagara shows the cultural absorption of regional deities by the imperial court.

Answer: (B)

Q12. Which structure in the Royal Centre features interior relief carvings illustrating narrative scenes from the **Ramayana**?

(A) Lotus Mahal
(B) Virupaksha Temple
(C) Hazara Rama Temple
(D) Mahanavami Dibba

Sol. Q12. The **Hazara Rama Temple**, situated in the Royal Centre and used primarily by the king and his immediate family, has walls adorned with sculpted episodes from the Ramayana.

Answer: (C)

Q13. Local merchant communities involved in the lucrative trade of imported Arabian war horses were known as:

(A) Chettiars
(B) Kudirai Chettis
(C) Banjaras
(D) Marwaris

Sol. Q13. Merchants dealing in horse trade were called **kudirai chettis** ("horse merchants"). They procured horses arriving at western ports.

Answer: (B)

Q14. Consider the following statements regarding the Mahanavami Dibba:

1. It is a massive stone platform rising to a height of 40 feet.
2. The ceremonies performed here coincided with the ten-day festival of Dussehra/ Navaratri.
3. The structure was constructed using imported Italian marble.

Which of the above statements is/are correct?

(A) 1 and 2 only
(B) 2 and 3 only
(C) 1 and 3 only
(D) 1, 2, and 3

Sol. Q14. Statements 1 and 2 are correct. Statement 3 is false; the platform was constructed using local granite stone with carved relief friezes, not Italian marble.

Answer: (A)

Q15. Which water reservoir, constructed in the fifteenth century, irrigated surrounding fields and conveyed water through an aqueduct into the Royal Centre?

(A) Hiriya Canal
(B) Kamalapuram Tank
(C) Sudarshana Lake
(D) Anandur Tank

Sol. Q15. The **Kamalapuram Tank**, built in the 15th century, stored rainwater runoff that both irrigated fields and supplied water to the Royal Centre through a masonry conduit channel.

Answer: (B)

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Wrong-Answer Clinic (CUET Traps & Common Misconceptions)

Common Mistake / Confusion	NTA Examination Trap	Correct Historical Fact & NCERT Clarification
Confusing the Dynasty of Krishnadeva Raya	Asserting he belonged to the founding Sangama dynasty.	Krishnadeva Raya belonged to the **Tuluva** dynasty (reigned 1509–1529). Harihara and Bukka founded the **Sangama** dynasty (1336).
Misinterpreting Abdur Razzaq's 7 Fortification Lines	Believing the 7 walls only enclosed the royal palace compounds.	The first three outer walls encircled agricultural tracts, fields, and forests. Only the inner walls protected the urban core and royal citadel.
Assuming Battle of Talikota ended the Empire completely	Assuming the entire empire ceased to exist in 1565.	The battle destroyed the capital Hampi, but the empire survived under the **Aravidu** dynasty from Penukonda and Chandragiri until the mid-17th century.
Attributing **Amuktamalyada** to Kannada	Matching Krishnadeva Raya's major work with Kannada or Sanskrit.	**Amuktamalyada** was composed in **Telugu**. He composed **Jambavati Kalyanam** in Sanskrit.
Confusing **Iqta** and **Amaranayaka** Nomenclature	Assuming Amaranayakas were central salaried bureaucrats.	Amaranayakas were military commanders assigned land territories (**amaram**). They collected local revenue, retained a portion for troops, and remitted surplus tribute annually.